

Where Freud and Lasch Align, and Where They Do Not

Sentence pairs from *The Future of an Illusion* and *The Illusion of Disillusionment*, with the reasons behind each agreement and disagreement

The earlier comparison document was organized by theme. This one is organized by passage. Each entry places a sentence or two from Freud beside a sentence or two from Lasch, verbatim, and then explains *why* the two align or fail to align. The aim is to show that the disagreements are not random: nearly all of them trace back to four root differences, which are named at the end.

Citations use F¶ and L¶ for Freud's and Lasch's numbered paragraphs, matching the handouts, the quiz site, and the study guides. Ellipses in brackets mark omitted words.

Part 1. Passages that align

Lasch built his speech on Freud's premises, so the alignments come first. In each case the two men are looking at the same fact and describing it in compatible terms.

1. Dependence never ends ALIGN

Both authors say that the helplessness of childhood is not something adults leave behind.

FREUD, F¶8

"the discovery that this helplessness would continue through the whole of life made it necessary to cling to the existence of a father - but this time a more powerful one."

LASCH, L¶15

"What makes the modern temper modern, then, is not that we have lost our childish sense of dependence but that the normal rebellion against dependence is more pervasive today than it used to be."

WHY THEY ALIGN

Freud's psychology and Lasch's history reach the same conclusion from different directions: the adult remains dependent. Freud finds this in the persistence of the "father complex" that is "never wholly overcome" (F¶8); Lasch finds it in the persistence of the religious problem across every age (L¶12). Neither believes in a truly independent human being. This shared premise is what makes the rest of their argument a real argument rather than two people talking about different things.

2. A belief driven by wish is suspect ALIGN

Freud's definition of illusion is adopted by Lasch without alteration.

FREUD, F¶9

"we call a belief an illusion when wish-fulfillment is a prominent factor in its motivation, while disregarding its relations to reality, just as the illusion itself does."

LASCH, L¶16

"Those wonderful machines that science has enabled us to construct have made it possible to imagine ourselves as master of our fate. In an age that fancies itself as disillusioned, this is the one illusion -- the illusion of mastery -- that remains as tenacious as ever."

WHY THEY ALIGN

Lasch's "illusion of mastery" fits Freud's definition exactly: a belief (that we control our fate) whose motivation is a wish and which persists regardless of its "relations to reality," in this case the limits of nature. Lasch even signals the borrowing, "to invoke Freud once again." The alignment is on method. The only change is the target: Freud aims the tool at religion, Lasch aims it at the people who think they have outgrown religion.

3. The world does not deliver justice ALIGN

Both treat the gap between what we deserve and what we get as the fact religion has to answer.

FREUD, F¶8

"the establishment of a moral world order ensures the fulfillment of the demands of justice, which within human culture have so often remained unfulfilled"

LASCH, L¶12

"Rebellion against God is the natural reaction to the discovery that the world was not made for our personal convenience. The further discovery that suffering is visited on the just and unjust alike is hard to square with a belief in a benign and omnipotent creator, as we know from the Book of Job."

WHY THEY ALIGN

The clause "so often remained unfulfilled" is Freud's version of Job's complaint. Both men accept that the problem of evil is real and that religion is a response to it. They part company only on the response: Freud says religion answers injustice with a promised "moral world order," Lasch says the tradition (Job) answers it by refusing the promise. Same wound, different treatment.

4. Watered-down religion is dishonest ALIGN

Both refuse a comfortable middle position in which religious words survive without religious substance.

FREUD, F¶11

"by calling 'God' some vague abstraction which they have created for themselves, they pose as deists, as believers, before the world; they may even pride themselves on having attained a higher and purer idea of God, although their God is nothing but an insubstantial shadow"

LASCH, L¶9

"religion is consistently treated as a source of intellectual and emotional security, rather than as a challenge to complacency and pride. Its ethical teachings are misconstrued as a body of simple commandments leaving no room for ambiguity or doubt."

WHY THEY ALIGN

Each is attacking a softened, domesticated religion: Freud the philosopher's abstraction, Lasch the modern commentator's "security." Both insist on religion at full strength, "the mighty personality of religious doctrine" for Freud (F¶11), "a challenge to complacency and pride" for Lasch. The alignment is real even though their reasons differ: Freud wants a clear target to reject, Lasch wants a demanding faith to defend.

5. Critical thinking, once learned, cannot be unlearned ALIGN

Both accept that there is no going back from the modern habit of criticism.

FREUD, F¶11

"Just as no one can be forced into belief, so no one can be forced into unbelief. But do not deceive yourself into thinking that with such arguments you are following the path of correct reasoning. [...] Ignorance is ignorance; no right to believe anything is derived from it."

LASCH, L¶12

"They cannot trade places with the unenlightened masses, however, any more than they can return to childhood. Once the critical habit of mind has been fully assimilated, no one who understands its implications can find any refuge or resting place in premodern systems of thought and belief."

WHY THEY ALIGN

Lasch is describing the modern condition from inside, and he does not pretend it can be reversed. Freud states the same thing as a demand for intellectual honesty. Where they will differ (Part 2, entry 6) is over what to call the resulting posture: Freud calls it correct reasoning, Lasch calls it pride. But on the bare fact that the critical mind cannot pretend to innocence, they agree.

6. Religion is a response, not a feeling**ALIGN ON LOCATION**

Both locate the essence of religion in what a person does about the human condition, not in the condition itself.

FREUD, F¶11

"it is not this feeling that constitutes the essence of religious emotion, but rather the next step, the reaction to it, which seeks a remedy against this feeling."

LASCH, L¶11

"Religious faith asserts the goodness of being in the face of suffering and evil. Black despair and alienation [...] often becomes the prelude to conversion."

WHY THEY ALIGN

Both reject the idea that feeling small, or feeling despair, is itself religious. Religion is "the next step" for Freud and what comes after "black despair" for Lasch. The structure is identical: condition, then response. This is the alignment that sets up the sharpest divergence, treated in Part 3, entry 4, because they characterize that response in opposite ways.

Part 2. Passages that do not align

Seven disagreements. In each entry the "why" traces the disagreement to its root, and the roots are collected in Part 4.

1. Were our ancestors ignorant children?

DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶15 AND F¶12

"these ancestors of ours were far more ignorant than we; they believed in things we could not possibly accept today"

"it would be still odder if our poor, ignorant, enslaved ancestors had succeeded in solving all these difficult riddles of the universe."

LASCH, L¶12 AND L¶10

"The unexamined premise that history can be compared to an individual's growth from childhood to maturity makes it possible to condemn any form of cultural conservatism or any respect for tradition as simply an expression of the natural human tendency to cling to the security of childhood"

"What has to be questioned here is the assumption [...] that religious people in the past were unacquainted with existential despair."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

Freud reasons that because our ancestors were wrong about many things (spontaneous generation, the causes of disease), their religious beliefs are probably also outdated. That inference only works if religious questions are like scientific questions, solved cumulatively over time. Lasch denies exactly that: the questions religion answers, death, evil, dependence, are faced fresh by every generation, so "more ignorant" does not apply. ROOT: a different theory of history. Freud's is progressive and cumulative; Lasch's is perennial.

2. Was questioning ever forbidden?

DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶14

"thirdly, because it is forbidden to raise the question of their authenticity at all. Formerly this presumptuous act was visited with the very severest penalties, and even to-day society is unwilling to see anyone renew it."

LASCH, L¶10

"The famous collection of songs written by medieval students preparing for the priesthood, Carmina Burana, should be enough in themselves to dispel this notion; they give voice, these disturbing compositions, to an age-old suspicion that the universe is ruled by Fortune, not by Providence"

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

This is a factual disagreement about the past. Freud generalizes from the institutional side of religion, heresy trials and official dogma. Lasch reads the lived side, the songs, the book of Job, the conversion narratives in William James. Both are looking at real evidence; they have chosen different evidence. ROOT: a different sample of religion. Freud samples the institution; Lasch samples the experience.

3. Does religion fulfil the wish or attack it? DO NOT ALIGN

The central disagreement. Lasch's sentence is a deliberate paraphrase-and-reversal of Freud's.

FREUD, F¶18

"they are illusions, fulfillments of the oldest, strongest and most insistent wishes of mankind; the secret of their strength is the strength of these wishes. [...] Thus the benevolent rule of divine providence allays our anxiety in face of life's dangers"

LASCH, L¶13

"According to its critics, religion provides the security of childlike dependence of a father figure who answers all our prayers. But the naive belief that our wishes govern the universe is precisely what religion attacks. We have no special claim on the universe, and our prayers are answered only when we surrender that claim."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

Read carefully, the two are describing two different religions. Freud's is the religion of providence, moral order, and afterlife, the religion most people are taught as children. Lasch's is the religion of the prophets and mystics, of Job and of James's converts, whose first lesson is surrender. Both religions exist. Neither author has refuted the other's example; each has picked the example that suits his case. **ROOT:** a different definition of religion. Freud defines it by its doctrines (F¶1); Lasch defines it by its spiritual practice (L¶11, L¶13).

4. What does science do to us? DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶10

"scientific work is our only way to the knowledge of external reality. Again, it is merely illusion to expect anything from intuition or trance"

LASCH, L¶15

"the normal rebellion against dependence appears to be sanctioned by our scientific control over nature -- the same progress of science that has allegedly destroyed religious superstition."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

The word "science" means different things in the two sentences. Freud means a method of finding out what is true. Lasch means a technological power and the cultural attitude it breeds. So Freud's claim (science is how we know) and Lasch's claim (science makes us feel like masters) can both be true. But the disagreement is still genuine, because Freud believes science dissolves illusions and Lasch believes it manufactures the biggest one. **ROOT:** a different sense of "science," epistemology for Freud, culture for Lasch.

5. Does faith promise happiness? DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶12

"it would indeed be very nice if there were a God, who was both creator of the world and a benevolent providence, if there were a moral world order and a future life, but at the same time it is very odd that this is all just as we should wish it ourselves."

LASCH, L¶14 AND L¶15

"they cannot see the central paradox of religious faith: that the secret of happiness lies in renouncing the right to be happy."

Quoting Flannery O'Connor: "there are long periods in the lives of all of us... when the truth as revealed by faith is hideous, emotionally disturbing, downright repulsive."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

Freud's entire "too convenient" argument depends on religion being pleasant. Lasch's evidence, O'Connor's "hideous" truth and the paradox of renouncing happiness, is chosen to show that for serious believers it is not pleasant at all. If Lasch is right about the content of faith, Freud's suspicion loses its object: there is nothing convenient to be suspicious of. **ROOT:** again the definition of religion, doctrine (which sounds nice) versus lived faith (which often does not).

6. Disillusionment: honesty or pride? DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶11

"No reasonable man will behave so frivolously in other matters or rest content with such feeble grounds for his opinions or for the attitude he adopts; it is only in the highest and holiest things that he allows this."

LASCH, L¶3 AND L¶6

"The intellectual alone looks straight into the light without blinking. Disillusioned but undaunted: Such is the self-image of modernity"

"Disillusionment, we might say, is the characteristic form of modern pride."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

They are evaluating the same posture, the person who refuses comforting belief. Freud calls that person reasonable; Lasch calls the self-congratulation that comes with it pride. Notice that both are practising suspicion of motives. Freud suspects the believer of clinging to comfort; Lasch suspects the unbeliever of enjoying his superiority. Each has caught a real form of motivated reasoning; neither has caught his own. **ROOT:** the shared tool of suspicion, pointed in opposite directions.

7. Which illusion has no future? DO NOT ALIGN

FREUD, F¶17

"It is to be expected that men will soon behave in like manner towards the religious fairy tales, despite the advocacy of the philosophy of 'As If.'"

LASCH, L¶16

"But now that we are beginning to grasp the limits of our control over the natural world, the future of this illusion (to invoke Freud once again) is very much in doubt -- more problematical, certainly than the future of religion."

WHY THEY DO NOT ALIGN

This one is settled by time rather than by argument. Freud made a prediction in 1927. Lasch, writing in 1991, reports that it had not come true and turns Freud's own title into the verdict. The deeper reason Freud's prediction failed is the point made in Part 1, entry 1: if dependence never ends, the response to it does not end either. Freud supplied the premise that undermines his own forecast.

Part 3. Same words, opposite meanings

The most revealing passages are the ones where the two writers use the same vocabulary and mean opposite things by it. These are neither simple alignments nor simple disagreements: they show precisely where the fork in the road is.

1. "Father" SAME WORD, OPPOSITE USE

FREUD, F¶18

"it was necessary to cling to the existence of a father - but this time a more powerful one."

LASCH, L¶13

"According to its critics, religion provides the security of childlike dependence of a father figure who answers all our prayers. But [...]"

WHY

Lasch quotes the concept only to discard it. For Freud the cosmic father is what religion *is*; for Lasch the cosmic father who "answers all our prayers" is what religion *attacks*. The word is a bridge between the texts and a marker of where they split.

2. "Illusion" SAME WORD, TRANSFERRED TARGET

FREUD, F¶10

"If after this survey we turn again to religious doctrines, we may reiterate that they are all illusions, they do not admit of proof"

LASCH, L¶16

"In an age that fancies itself as disillusioned, this is the one illusion -- the illusion of mastery -- that remains as tenacious as ever."

WHY

Both titles contain the word, and both use Freud's definition. What moves is the object. The alignment on the concept (Part 1, entry 2) is what makes the disagreement on the object so pointed: Lasch is convicting modernity with Freud's own law.

3. "Children" and "childhood"

SAME METAPHOR, OPPOSITE VERDICT

FREUD, F¶17 (AND FREUD AS QUOTED IN L¶11)

"I am reminded of one of my children who was distinguished at an early age by a peculiarly marked sense of reality. [...] he would come forward and ask: Is that a true story?"

"men cannot remain children for ever."

LASCH, L¶18

"Those who mourn the death of the past and those who acclaim it both take for granted that our age has outgrown its childhood. Both find it difficult to believe that history still haunts our enlightened, disillusioned adolescence (or maturity or senility or whatever stage of the life cycle we have allegedly reached)."

WHY

For Freud, childhood is credulity, and the clear-eyed child who asks "is it true?" is the model for humanity growing up. For Lasch the whole childhood-to-maturity metaphor is the error, and his sarcastic parenthesis ("or senility or whatever stage") is aimed at Freud's confidence that we know which stage we are in. The metaphor Freud uses as a tool is, for Lasch, the thing to be examined.

4. Acquiescence and surrender

SAME ACT, OPPOSITE NAME

The single most important pair in the two readings.

FREUD, F¶11

"He who goes no further, he who humbly acquiesces in the insignificant part man plays in the universe, is, on the contrary, irreligious in the truest sense of the word."

LASCH, L¶111 AND L¶113

"An awareness of 'radical evil' underlies the spiritual intoxication that finally comes with 'yielding' and 'self-surrender.'"

"We have no special claim on the universe, and our prayers are answered only when we surrender that claim. Such is the true meaning of religious faith"

WHY

Freud and Lasch describe the identical act, humbly accepting human insignificance, and attach opposite labels: "irreligious in the truest sense" and "the true meaning of religious faith." No further evidence could settle this, because it is not a disagreement about facts. It is a disagreement about what the word "religion" names. Freud names the doctrines, which promise a remedy for insignificance, so accepting insignificance without a remedy is by his definition irreligious. Lasch names the practice of the prophets and saints, for whom acceptance is the remedy. Every other disagreement in Part 2 is downstream of this one.

Part 4. The four roots

Almost every alignment and every disagreement above can be traced to one of four underlying differences, plus one shared foundation.

Shared foundation. Both begin from lifelong human dependence and both distrust wish-driven belief (Part 1, entries 1 and 2). This is why Lasch can use Freud's tools, and why the debate is a real one.

Root 1: theory of history. Freud thinks knowledge accumulates, so the past is more ignorant than the present (F¶5, F¶12). Lasch thinks the deepest questions are perennial, so the past is a contemporary (L¶2, L¶10, L¶12). Produces Part 2, entries 1 and 7.

Root 2: sample of religion. Freud looks at institutional doctrine and official prohibition (F¶4); Lasch looks at the lived and literary record, Job, the Carmina Burana, James, O'Connor (L¶10, L¶11, L¶15). Produces Part 2, entries 2 and 5.

Root 3: definition of religion. Freud defines religion as a set of dogmas (F¶1) and therefore by what the dogmas promise. Lasch defines it as a practice of surrender (L¶11, L¶13) and therefore by what faith demands. Produces Part 2, entry 3, and all of Part 3, above all the acquiescence/surrender pair.

Root 4: meaning of "science." Freud means a method of knowing (F¶10); Lasch means a technological power and the attitude it fosters (L¶15, L¶16). Produces Part 2, entries 4 and 6.

The practical lesson for reading the two together: when you find a sentence in one author, ask which root it grows from. If it concerns dependence or wish, expect the other author to agree. If it concerns history, evidence, the definition of religion, or science, expect him to disagree, and you will usually be able to say why.

Part 5. Paragraph index

Every numbered paragraph, its closest counterpart in the other text, and the state of alignment.

FREUD	COUNTERPART	STATUS	WHY
F¶1	L¶9, L¶10	DIVERGE	Freud defines religion as dogma; Lasch says that definition is the modern mistake (Root 3).
F¶2	L¶12	PARTLY	Both accept "go and see" for facts; Lasch says religion's questions are not that kind (Root 3).
F¶3	L¶2, L¶13	PARTLY	Both prize critical inquiry; disagree on whether knowledge of limits counts as knowledge (Root 4).
F¶4	L¶10	DIVERGE	Questioning forbidden (Freud) vs. doubt inside the tradition (Lasch) (Root 2).
F¶5	L¶2, L¶6	DIVERGE	Ignorant ancestors vs. the "unexamined premise" of modern pride (Root 1).
F¶6	L¶11	DIVERGE	Inner experience proves nothing (Freud) vs. despair-to-surrender is faith's core (Lasch) (Root 3).
F¶7	L¶3, L¶16	DIVERGE	Prediction of religion's end vs. its record; the clear-eyed child vs. the proud intellectual (Root 1).
F¶8	L¶13, L¶15	PARTLY	Same premise (lifelong helplessness), opposite conclusion (wish fulfilled vs. wish surrendered) (Root 3).
F¶9	L¶16	ALIGN	Lasch adopts Freud's definition of illusion and applies it to mastery (shared foundation).
F¶10	L¶15, L¶16	PARTLY	Both reject cafeteria religion; disagree on what science does (Root 4).
F¶11	L¶9, L¶11, L¶13	PARTLY	Both scorn vague religion; acquiescence is "irreligious" vs. "self-surrender" is faith (Root 3).
F¶12	L¶10, L¶14	DIVERGE	Religion is "very nice" vs. faith is "hideous" and renounces happiness; ancestors naive vs. not (Roots 1, 2).

LASCH	COUNTERPART	STATUS	WHY
L¶1	F¶5, F¶7, F¶12	DIVERGE	Lasch describes the life-cycle myth; Freud holds it sincerely (Root 1).
L¶2	F¶11	PARTLY	Both: criticism is irreversible. Lasch: the premise behind it is unexamined (Root 1).
L¶3	F¶7, F¶11	DIVERGE	The intellectual's self-image: honesty for Freud, pose for Lasch (Root 4, via shared suspicion).
L¶4	F¶3, F¶5, F¶10	DIVERGE	Freud reads history as the progress of critical reason, one of the two shapes Lasch rejects (Root 1).

L¶5	F¶12	PARTLY	Both: progress costs illusions. Freud pays the price gladly; Lasch doubts the story (Root 1).
L¶6	F¶11	DIVERGE	Disillusionment as pride vs. as honesty (shared suspicion, opposite target).
L¶7	F¶10	PARTLY	Freud has no nostalgia but holds the progress half of Lasch's pair (Root 1).
L¶8	F¶5, F¶8	PARTLY	Freud's history denies the past's hold; Freud's psychology ("never wholly overcome") affirms it.
L¶9	F¶8, F¶11	DIVERGE	Religion as security is Freud's thesis and Lasch's caricature; both scorn vague religion (Root 3).
L¶10	F¶4, F¶12	DIVERGE	Carmina Burana vs. "severest penalties" and "enslaved ancestors" (Root 2).
L¶11	F¶6, F¶11	PARTLY	Both: religion responds to suffering. Surrender is faith (Lasch) vs. irreligion (Freud) (Root 3).
L¶12	F¶8	PARTLY	Both: the world is not made for us and justice fails. Invent a father vs. accept the fact (Root 3).
L¶13	F¶8, F¶9	DIVERGE	Direct reversal of the wish-fulfilment thesis, using Freud's own suspicion of wish (Root 3).
L¶14	F¶12	DIVERGE	"Very nice if there were a God" vs. "renouncing the right to be happy" (Roots 2, 3).
L¶15	F¶8, F¶10	PARTLY	Both: dependence is lifelong. Freud's cure (science) is Lasch's rebellion (Root 4).
L¶16	F¶7, F¶9, F¶10	DIVERGE	Title turned against its author; Freud's alchemist example concedes science can serve a wish (Roots 1, 4).

Count: 6 clear alignments of passages, 7 clear non-alignments, 4 shared terms with opposite meanings. Of the 28 paragraphs, 1 aligns fully, 13 partly, and 14 diverge. The high number of "partly" rows is the signature of this pair of texts: Lasch agrees with Freud's premises far more often than with his conclusions.